



THE WALL FALLS

The rear wall of the Jaisalmer Fort in a state of imminent collapse; and (below); water seepage from inside the fort is causing the fort walls to weaken. These are problems endemic in a living monument but are exacerbated by the pressures of population and commercialisation.



ON THE EDGE OF A PRECIPICE

1993 After monsoons, 250 historic buildings collapse, including the oldest existing Rajput palace—Rani-ka Mahal.

1996 Listed in the first World Monuments Watch list of 100 Most Endangered Monuments in the world.

1998-99 Six people die when an exterior wall falls. A portion of the lower fortification wall and two bastions break.

2001 Tremors from the Gujarat earthquake cause substantial damage to several buildings.

2007 A study by Geological Survey of India shows three faultlines running under the fort.

sedimentary rock units, it is likely that these weaker units, when they come into contact with water, get facilitated especially during tremors". There is also a slight shifting of the hill behind the fort, which has a 3.5 km long wall at least 30 km high, which can only be arrested by engineering intervention.

Instead of panic, though, the findings have been met with apathy. There was a public hearing in Jaisalmer in September where ASI, local authorities and the consultants working on the fort shared the data with residents—another one is slated for December. But even those meant to enforce the laws are violating them: the state government has built a *mandi* along the fort wall and there was also a plan to build a shopping wall, now nixed. World Monuments Fund consultant Amita Baig, who was present at the hearing, believes saving the fort is not

possible without the understanding and acceptance by its inhabitants of how grave their situation is.

But ASI, which has been protecting the fort since 1951, has been fighting a losing battle. There is a law that says the superintending archaeologist, Jaipur Circle, is to be asked for permission for construction of houses within the regulated area (200 metres from the fort) but this is rarely followed. In a status report in 2001, ASI had admitted that "a major portion of the fort being under private ownership, an agreement is required to be executed with the owners of the private properties, but it is entirely unfulfilled so far". It also pointed to the "modern, unauthorised constructions on the bastions which need to be vacated and its population shifted elsewhere". The problem, according to ASI, is clearly lack of jurisdiction. The habitation

inside the fort is under the municipality, and now there are buildings up to four floors tall right on the edge of the bastions. As Jaisalmer travel agent and guest house owner Manoj G. Poljiwala says, it is not clear who is responsible for the fort—ASI or the municipality. "Why don't they give us a master plan and tell us which construction is permissible and which is not?"

As for the sewage situation it is now truly dire. In 2001, the total cost of works to be executed by the Public Health Engineering Department was said to be Rs 1.28 crore—small potatoes in a town that has seen an enormous inflow of foreign funds raised by NGOs such as JIJ. Much of the drainage trouble is said to have begun in 1985 when Rs 90 lakh was spent on replacing open sewers with covered drains, which ended with water seeping into

"No change is possible without the people understanding how grave the threat is."

AMITA BAIG, CONSULTANT, WORLD MONUMENTS FUND